

Q Can breathing techniques really help me to cope in labor?

When we feel anxious or worried, we tend to hold our breath, which reduces the oxygen circulating in our blood, and we tense up, tightening muscles and restricting blood flow.

In this state of hyperarousal, the perception of pain is greater, and labor becomes harder work. Conversely, calm and steady breathing lowers the heart rate, reduces anxiety, and maximizes the oxygen flow to you and your baby. If you learn breathing techniques (see p.72) before labor, you can use these to help you breathe purposefully through your contractions, focusing in particular on breathing out (releasing) as the contraction peaks, so you remain as relaxed as possible. Techniques such as Hypnobirthing (see p.73), an increasingly

popular practice that anecdotally has positive results, use breathing techniques to help you focus during contractions and breathe through the pain, rather than try to resist it.

Q My midwife asked if I was interested in using a birthing pool. How does water help labor?

Getting into a warm bath is a well-known relaxation aid. Similarly, being immersed in warm water in labor can be instantly soothing. As your muscles relax, levels of endorphins, the feel-good hormones that provide natural pain relief, increase; and it's thought that the warm water blocks pain messages from getting to your brain, reducing your perception of pain. Being in water also makes it easier to move

around since the water supports your belly, so you can rely on your own sense of balance and buoyancy to change position, rather than the strength of your birth partner or midwife. If you are using a birthing pool at home, it's up to you when you get in, but some experts believe that it's best to wait until labor is established since it's thought that warm water may slow contractions early on. The water shouldn't be above 99.5°F (37.5°C) since higher than this can raise your core temperature and distress your baby. You can stay in the pool as long as you like, and, if you have a midwife trained in water birth, you can give birth in it, too. If you don't have a birthing pool, you can benefit from the soothing effects of water by lying in a warm bath.

You'll need to have someone with you while you are in water to make sure you don't become so drowsy that you fall asleep and slip under the surface, and to help you to get in and out.

Q I've heard about women using meditation in labor. How does this work?

Techniques such as meditation attempt to redirect your focus away from the pain of labor to help raise your pain threshold. Meditation is simply the act of stilling the mind so that you can remain detached from the physical sensations in your body. The idea is that if you train your mind to believe that you will be able to deal with the pain of labor, you are far more likely to manipulate your experience to that end, whereas if you tell yourself labor is going to be unbearably painful, you'll almost certainly experience the full force of your pain.

Choosing a visualization or affirmation to focus on during meditation can help:

» Visualize a stream that tumbles over stones—can you see the light on the water? How fast does the water move? What sounds does it make? Does it splash or foam as it flows? The more detail you can conjure up, the more focus you have away from your pain.

» Visualize a candle flame. To keep the outbreath long and slow through a contraction, close your eyes and imagine blowing it so gently that the flame flickers, but doesn't go out.

Monitoring your baby In a birthing pool your baby's heartbeat will be monitored with a waterproof handheld device.

